

The unwritten manual of becoming a professor of HCI

Florian Michahelles

florian.michahelles@tuwien.ac.at
TU Wien
Austria

Susanne Boll

susanne.boll@uol.de
University of Oldenburg
Germany

Katie Siek

ksiek@indiana.edu
Indiana University Bloomington
USA

Flora Salim

flora.salim@unsw.edu.au
UNSW Sydney
Australia

Aaron Quigley

aquigley@acm.org
Data61
Australia

ABSTRACT

This course is about preparing researchers for a permanent career in academia. Based on personal practice the course organizers will describe the settings, roles, procedures, and motivations of search and appointment committees. Furthermore, the course will cover strategies for preparing a successful lecture talk, scientific talk, and plans and vision talk. Finally, this course will discuss the do's and don't for the interview on leadership and social competencies. A dedicated module on training pitches will enable participants to practice concepts on-site and provide peer review among each other.

The organizers will provide a safe space for sharing following the Chatham house rules.

CCS CONCEPTS

• **Human-centered computing** → **Human computer interaction (HCI)**.

KEYWORDS

hci, career, professpr

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1 INTRODUCTION

Professors are specialized in a variety of academic fields and conduct research on their areas of expertise. In addition to completing Ph.D. studies and developing a standing in a specialized field becoming a professor depends on succeeding in an application process which follows its own rules and practices. This requires communication skills, interpersonal skills, and the ability to explain and explore new ideas with others.

Generally, there is no recipe for succeeding but plenty of experiences, best practices, and do's and don'ts. Furthermore, different circumstances of life, personal choice, and flexibility determine the different journeys toward a professorship. We are a group of four instructors having made our own choices and experiences which we are happy to share and discuss in this course. We will not only share stories of successes but also those of failures, of mismatches of expectations and positive and negative surprises in these processes. These go along with established procedures and roles involved in hiring processes which just become apparent by experience. This course intends to provide the unwritten manual for becoming a professor of HCI.

2 BENEFITS TO PARTICIPANTS

Participants will learn about the process, roles, and motives involved in the hiring process. They will also learn to tailor a presentation for the needs of a selection committee, let their topic stand out, and market themselves. While researchers are trained in scientific methods, hiring is a people business, and conveying facts and results is just one way of convincing people. This will become apparent even more during the interview. We will provide some strategies and short exercises to practice. Finally, participants will learn how to stand in for their needs and interests during a negotiation of a prospective position.

2.1 Common tips

- Do what you like most: you will do it better, you'll be enthusiastic to tell and teach others, build collaboration, have more fun, and be more successful.
- How to shape your contribution to the field: what do you do? why does it matter? why does it matter to you? where does it connect, where is it unique? what is next?
- How to find a network of peers: colleagues in your, your institute, your field. Visit summer schools, conduct workshops, volunteer for conference roles, and participate in your institution.
- How to build up a network of mentors: seek out people that inspire you, build up a connection, think about what you can offer, collaborate on projects, and benefit from their experience and know-how and network.
- Understand the stakeholders, their roles, and expectations involved in the hiring process: professors of a university looking for a new expert in a dedicated field without being deep into the field themselves, the dean who is concerned about

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the institute, the diversity manager who cares about representation, students who look for inspiring teachers and mentors, the rector/president thinking about money/media/prestige, the reviewers who seek for excellence and representation of their field, external selection committee members who care about the field.

- Understand the process: application, hearing, negotiation

3 INTENDED AUDIENCE

This course introduces the best practices and personal experiences of the instructor to an audience entering the academic application process for professorship positions. Thus, the course is primarily targeting post-docs shaping their own research agenda. However, as there are different life journeys leading towards a professorship, this course is also beneficial for people returning from industry and non-university research institutes. The expectation for the course audiences is that people are intending to submit or have submitted their first professorship application and see themselves in a research field related to human-computer interaction.

4 PREREQUISITES

There are no prerequisites for this course other than visiting the online course materials before the conference to familiarize oneself with some of the course concepts. The participants are expected to be ready to present themselves and their topics to the course without slides in a very short intro talk.

5 CONTENT

The course is structured into four units (see Table 1), the first one on the stakeholders involved in the hiring of a professor, the second one on the presentation(s) at a hearing, the third one on handling questions at the interview, and the fourth one on negotiating. At the start of the first unit, the participants are introduced to the course instructors and the course goals:

- Understand your goals for HCI research, and why you even would want to expand this as a professor
- Learn how to convey your research to others
- Learn about the unwritten do's and don't during the interview in front of the hiring committee

5.1 Unit 1: Stakeholders

This unit introduces the different roles of stakeholders involved in your hiring process. It will give participants an overview of what the different roles are looking for during the application process and describe their motivation and intention. This should provide some meaningful guidance on how to navigate successfully through this multi-stakeholder scenario.

5.2 Unit 2: Presenting at a hearing

Presenting a paper at a conference is different from presenting at a hearing. Even though the invitation to a hearing may ask for the preparation of a scientific talk, the audience in the hearing has less expertise in the field and is more interested in the candidate and prospective future than the topic itself. We will review best practices and present examples of personal experience.

5.3 Unit 3: Succeeding in the interview

Whereas the scientific talk may be the most explicitly articulated preparation for the hearing, the following interview gives the committee an even deeper insight into understanding the candidate's competencies, skills, and motivation. This unit will review 'usual suspect' questions and present techniques to successfully master them.

5.4 Unit 4: Negotiating

When you have excelled in the interview and convinced the commission about yourself, the next step is to negotiate with the head of the school or head of the department potential categories of personal accommodations, research infrastructure, staff, and startup grants. We will review tips and tracks for composing a sound proposal and yielding a successful outcome.

6 PARTICIPATION

All four units feature bits of discussion input and personal sharing. Since these are all very personal matters, the course will follow the Chatham House rules, i.e. participants are free to use the information received, but neither the identity nor the affiliation of the speaker(s), nor that of any other participant, may be revealed.

7 INSTRUCTOR BACKGROUND

Florian Michahelles is a professor of ubiquitous computing at TU Wien in Austria. Before, he spent seven years in industry. On his career journey, he has collected manifold experiences as an applicant about success and failure. He has participated in hiring committees in different roles both in industry and academia.

Susanne Boll is a professor of Media Informatics and Multimedia Systems at the University of Oldenburg. In her career she has applied for different positions, several of them successful and others not. She has been acting as a member of several selection committees in HCI, computer science, and related field in different roles as a member, external member, and also an equal opportunities representative.

Katie Sieck is a professor and chair of Informatics at Indiana University. Her primary research interests are in human computer interaction, health informatics, and ubiquitous computing. More specifically, she is interested in how sociotechnical interventions affect personal health and well being.

Flora Salim is the inaugural Cisco Chair of Digital Transport, School of Computer Science and Engineering, UNSW Sydney. Her research sits in the cross-cutting areas of ubiquitous computing, machine learning, and data science, with specific interests on time-series and spatio-temporal data and data-efficient learning with multimodal sensor data. She is an Editor of PACM IMWUT and a member of UbiComp Steering Committee.

Aaron Quigley is the Science Director and Deputy Director of CSIRO's Data61 in Australia. He has held roles as Professor of HCI and Head of School in UNSW and as Professor of HCI and Director of SICSA in the University of St Andrews UK. Aaron's research interests include discreet computing, global HCI, pervasive and ubiquitous computing and information visualisation and he is an ACM Distinguished Member.

8 RESOURCES

Further resources will be made available to the participants on our website.¹

9 ACCESSIBILITY

To make everything accessible, all materials will be provided as recordings and transcripts, so that participants can follow along.

For all website materials, the instructor will ensure to provide meaningful ALT text for images and colorblind-safe color schemes. Recorded Online Videos will be subtitled.

¹<http://media.tuwien.ac.at/hciprof>